

—probably the only romantic relationship in his life—with the painter Suzanne Valadon; his devastation when she left after six months was a factor in the great changes in both his lifestyle and his music that followed.

In 1895, a small inheritance marked the beginning of a new phase in Satie's life. He used some of the money to buy seven identical gray velvet corduroy suits, ditching the clerical robes and his obsession with religious cults. The money also gave him the opportunity to publish some of his humorous writings, and the time to compose.

However, funds eventually ran out and Satie was forced to move from Paris. He took a room in the suburb of Arcueil, which was his home for the rest of his life. He lived alone, never received visitors, apart from stray dogs, and to the outside world presented himself as a respectable gentleman who walked into the city every day to earn a modest living as a pianist. However, behind that exterior was an extraordinary mind and a wicked sense of humor.

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For some years, Satie's musical output was limited to making arrangements of popular songs and composing cabaret-style pieces, which he later dismissed as lightweight. Still intent on making composing his career, in 1905 he enrolled in the Schola Cantorum de Paris, a conservatory that stressed plainsong in its teaching, to study under Vincent d'Indy and Albert Roussel. This was a great surprise to those who knew him, because the Schola was steeped in the 19th-century tradition, and his teachers were